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SUNDAY SCARE

October 28, 1962, happened to be a Sunday. In Russian that day of the week is called *voskresenie*, meaning “resurrection.” The Bolsheviks, who came to power in 1917 with the goal of building communism and eradicating religion, were uneasy about keeping a Christian name for a day of rest. Accordingly, in the middle of an antireligious campaign in 1929, they switched from a seven-day week to a five-day cycle with no place for a “resurrection” day. The new calendar added some days free of labor, but the population resisted the change, remaining loyal to the old calendar. In 1940, as Stalin prepared the country for war and became concerned about the loyalty of Soviet citizens, he reversed the policy, switching back to a seven-day week and reestablishing Sunday.[1]

With few churches open, people no longer attended services as a matter of course. Instead they slept in on the only free day of the week—Saturdays would not become work-free until the late 1960s. For those concerned about the rapidly worsening international situation, Sunday morning